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PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

COMMUNICATION BY THE SPEAKER—

Practice and Procedure Week— [Col. 4]

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 6]

PAPER—

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture Development for the year 2024— [Col. 43]

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Ghana Scholarship Authority Bill, 2025—[Col. 45]

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS— [Col. 23]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 104]

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 29th October, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 2:34 p.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we would not take the roll call today and I do not have any message from His Excellency the President. I would be communicating to you a formal Statement but before I do that, I just want to underscore the importance of attendance to plenary sessions.

I understood the people of Ghana to have overly tolerated us in the Eighth Parliament for a good reason. The Eighth Parliament was a delicate Parliament; a hung Parliament. As a country, we have had an experience before when we had the Third Republic and I have drawn your attention to this. It was also a hung Parliament so Ghanaians learnt a lesson from that and tolerated us. The elections have given us another extreme swing: a populous majority. But whatever we say, because of our other commitments which most likely take us out of plenary sessions, the message is not accepted by Ghanaians. Because during Meetings, the priority should be plenary sessions.

2:44 p.m.

The Speaker: I am not happy with the way Hon Members value Plenary sessions. Those of you who are always here, I see from your faces that you are with me in this matter. Before I usually commence proceedings, I always take a count of those present; I am not happy with the situation. I did indicate from the very beginning of this Meeting that I have the records of attendance for the First Meeting and the Second Meeting. I decided for good reason not to publish them, but to give you the last opportunity. It looks like I made a catastrophic mistake. I should have brought it out and referred Hon Members to the Privileges Committee. I thought that was not a good way to start this Third Meeting, but it is like it has encouraged Hon Members not to be present.

There are 276 strong Hon Members of Parliament. It is for good reason we decided that we will sit in the afternoons, so that you can take the morning to attend to Committees, prepare your Reports, attend to your constituents, and that by 2 o'clock p.m., you will be ready to Sit. Again, that is a period you can also interact with the ministries, because there is a time established by law for public servants to report to work and to close from work. So, that is a good time for you to have the opportunity to interact and chase things for and on behalf of your constituents. It is for these good reasons we decided to start Sitting at 2 o'clock p.m.

I also encouraged it due to the fact that the time people are working, they may not have the opportunity to observe

you and participate in whatever you do, but in the evenings, they would have the opportunity to sit, watch, advise you, and also make some inputs. That, again, we are not taking advantage of.

I am saying this for the last time. I have given directive to the Clerks-at-the-Table to take the records for this Meeting, and please, we have the Standing Orders, and we know what they say. We will be taking action to make

sure that we compel Hon Members to Sit or to be considered to have vacated their seats. On this matter, I will say no more.

FORMAL COMMUNICATION BY THE SPEAKER

Practice and Procedure Week

The Speaker: I would proceed with the second communication.

COMMUNICATION FROM THE CHAIR

Subject: Maiden Practice and Procedure Week of Parliament

Honourable Members,

This is to inform the House that the **Parliamentary Service**, through the **Legislative Management Services Area**, is organising the maiden edition of the **Practice and Procedure Week** from **Monday, 3rd to Saturday 8th November 2025**.

This initiative forms part of the continuing efforts to enhance institutional efficiency, professionalism, and procedural consistency in the conduct of parliamentary business.

The objective of the **Practice and Procedure Week** is to build the knowledge and skills of both Honourable Members and staff in parliamentary procedure, ethics, and best practices. It also provides an opportunity for collective reflection and exchange on modern trends in legislative management.

The objective is aligned with Parliament's broader institutional modernisation agenda, particularly in the areas of—

- **Digitisation and integration of technology** into legislative workflows;
- **Strengthening the capacity and effectiveness of Committees** for enhanced oversight; and
- **Promoting civic engagement and transparency** in the work of Parliament.

Throughout the Week, there will be seminars, panel discussions, and interactive sessions involving current and former Members of Parliament, Clerks and other procedure officers and staff, all aimed at deepening procedural knowledge and improving operational efficiency.

I accordingly urge all Honourable Members to participate actively in the scheduled activities of the **Practice and Procedure Week**, as the insights gained will further strengthen the institution and improve the quality of service rendered to the Ghanaian people. The programme will be formally opened by the Rt Hon Speaker on **Monday 3rd November 2025** at the **Justice D.F. Annan Auditorium**.

Rt. Hon. Speaker
Parliament of Ghana

Hon Members, kindly pass on this information to your Colleagues and make it a point to be present. It will be a very engaging week, and we hope at the end of the day, Hon Members will be better equipped, this House will be strengthened, doors will be opened for our partners, particularly, the public and civil society, to engage us, for us to collectively entrench democratic culture in our country. I thank you for the listenership.

Let me on your behalf acknowledge the presence of students from the Maase Presby Basic School. They are led here by the Headteacher of the school, Mr Michael Addae, and this school is located in the Abuakwa South constituency. They are 68 in number, and are very visible at the right side of the public podium. I want on your behalf to warmly welcome them, and to congratulate the organisers for doing a good job.

2:54 p.m.

This number is quite huge, but they should not be discouraged by the cost, because the benefits are more than the cost. Please take a few minutes, look at your Members, listen to what they say and learn a few things. Even though you are very young now, as you grow older, get to higher positions and perform better than this, you will recall this day you were in Parliament.

So, Headmaster, congratulations on leading the team. I see that you have a number of tutors, particularly our women, and a few gentlemen. I am only

identifying you by your size, and I am assuming that you are tutors. So you are welcome, and please resume your seats.

[Pupils of the Maase Presbyterian Basic School were acknowledged]

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

The Speaker: Now, we move on to the next item, the item numbered 5 on the Order Paper, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

We start with the correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 28th October, 2025. Page 1...9—

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much. Just a minor correction. The page under review, the third paragraph, and the very last line, after “Article 60(8)”, the next word should be deleted so that we *insert* ‘of the’ before the “1992 Constitution.”

The Speaker: Thank you, Hon Member. Table Office, kindly take note.

Page 10...15—Yes?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, as always, your guidance is supreme. Page 15, the item numbered vi, “Principal, Seventh Day Adventist College of Education.” Mr Speaker, my understanding is that there are two of them, so if the Clerks-at-the-Table could, specifically, add the one in reference over here.

Again, on the same page, the item numbered iii, “President, National Conference of Principals of Colleges of Education and Principal”—There should be a comma before “Accra College of Education”.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Member, I got your second correction. The first one is what I do not seem to have seen on my copy. The vi, we have “Principal, Seventh Day Adventist College of Education”. That is what I have.

Mr Afriyie: Yes, Mr Speaker, truly so, but I was seeking your guidance because there are two Seventh Day Adventist Colleges of Education in the country, per my understanding. One is in Agona, and the other is in Asokore. I do not know which of them is in reference here. That is why I was trying to draw the attention of the Clerks-at-the-Table to specifically tell us which of them.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Clerks-at-the-Table, please identify the location of the College of Education.

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of the fifth Sitting, dated Tuesday, 28th October 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

I have two copies of the *Official Reports*. The first is dated 21st October, 2025, and the second, 22nd October,

2025. Hon Members, do you have copies so that we can start corrections? Silence means consent. So we start with that of Tuesday, 21st October, 2025. Any corrections, Members?

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, if you may, I wish to elect you for high praise. I have seen lots of innovations here. We thank you so much because it has given us more details.

Column 36, the very first line, “Ministry of Environment, Science, Technology and Innovation”. In this particular regime, we have the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology. So if we could *delete* the word ‘Innovation’.

Then again, Mr Speaker, with your kind indulgence, column 43, paragraph 3, line 7, Environmental Protection Agency. If we could *delete* ‘Agency’ and replace it with ‘Authority’. Then the very last one, column 59, the item numbered (ii), under Ministry of Education. The “Akenten Appiah-Menka University of Skills Training and Entrepreneurial Development” is one word; over here it is separated. If that could be corrected.

Thank you so much, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Member, I commend you highly for your eagle eye and your editorial skills. It is not easy for many to see this.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

The Speaker: It is not easy, so we thank you so much.

Please, the Office of Chamber Reporting should take note, and Clerks-at-the-Table, draw their attention to it.

3:04 p.m.

The last one he referred to affected the next rendition and they should be separated. You have “ii” and “iii”. Please, kindly take note.

Yes, Hon Member?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, *Official Report* of Tuesday, 21st October, 2025, on page (vii). There is under the —

Mr Speaker: Hon Member, I did not hear you. What did you say?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, column (vii), on the first line under alphabet “m”, we have “Mahama Abdul Kabiru Tiah” with “Esquire (Esq)” attached to it. The “Esq” is not part. It may be replaced with PhD or Dr. I think that will do. The era of Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC)—It is so common. I am not Esquire. I am —

Mr Speaker: Which page did you refer to?

Dr Mahama: That is the *Official Report* of Tuesday, 21st October, 2025.

Mr Speaker: Your Colleagues are seriously correcting you, but you are not paying attention.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I corrected that. You said column (vii). I am saying the *Official Report* of Tuesday, 21st October, 2025, column (vii). I said —

Mr Speaker: You were not saying “column”; you were saying “page”.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, rightly so. When I was corrected on the first instance, I came back with the right rendition, but I mistakenly said “page (vii)” initially.

Mr Speaker: But you meant column—

Dr Mahama: Column (vii), Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, he is crying over his head, so please understand him. He is not “Esquire”, so kindly delete that from his name. He does not want GTEC to have problems with him, but my good Son who mentioned GTEC, I am not sure I will err if I called Azumah Nelson “Professor”. Hon Members, would I be wrong?

Dr Mahama: It is wrong.

Mr Speaker: Why?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Rules are that honorary professorship is not supposed to be recognised as such, that you call yourself a professor just because you have been honoured. Professorship that is acquired academically or by way of promotion is what is legally accepted to be used and to be called as such.

Mr Speaker: What is your name?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, my name is Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama.

Mr Speaker: Were you the one who gave yourself the name? *[Laughter]*

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, no. I did not give myself the name. My parents actually conferred that name on me at birth and registered it as such.

Mr Speaker: So, if I confer professorship on Azumah Nelson, you are saying that that would be wrong? Why?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, it is because there are regulations guiding it. I cannot call myself “Esquire” because I have not been to the Ghana School of Law. Why would I want to assume “Esquire” when I have not been to the Ghana School of Law? Why would one want to call themselves a professor or The Speaker when they are not duly conferred as the Speaker?

Mr Speaker, I think that your nephew is doing the right thing.

Mr Speaker: I know that most you are referred to as ‘Speakers’ in your constituencies. *[Laughter]* Well, maybe — **[An Hon Member:** Number 3] — No, we are not talking about numbers. *[Laughter]* I know about a lot of youth parliaments, either in schools or in communities. They have a lot of parliaments and they have a lot of Speakers. They do not need it to be conferred on them by this House, but

they are Speakers. If you are dealing with academia and you talk about professorship, yes, GTEC is 100 per cent right. Outside of academia, if you are dealing with skills, competences and other areas of specialty, there is nothing wrong in calling the person either doctor, professor or whatever. But in academia, there is everything wrong.

Long before you were born, there were a lot of professions that were called learned professions; education was one, medicine was another, and law was the other. Only lawyers decided to continue to call themselves “learned friend”; the others dropped it along the line. Are you with me? This is a very controversial area. I not need you to debate me on this matter; I want GTEC to debate me. I have invited GTEC to come and debate me and convince me that it is wrong—

I have not invited any young lady into this matter. This is the Speaker expressing his free speech. If I am wrong, you are all allowed to say that, “Mr Speaker, for this one, you got it wrong.” But because I was born before you — *[Laughter]*.

I know that all the titles we give to Aristotle were given names. God created us and those of you who are learned in the Bible know that we gave names to all the creation. So, names are given; titles too are given. There are some—Yes, Professor Azumah Nelson earned it; maybe the time he was in full flight, you were not born.

Hon Members, let us complete the correction of the *Official Report*.

Mr Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh: Mr Speaker, I think the issue raised by my Hon Colleague is a general issue. When you go to column (iii), “Alphabetical list of Members of Parliament”, it appears that virtually everybody there is an Esquire. Even my name has an Esquire. I have seen a lot of names with Esquire, for instance, Charles Forson has Esquire too. Virtually everybody is an Esquire here. I do not know if the Clerks-at-Table would advert their attention to it and correct it.

Alternatively, Mr Speaker, because it is a given name, we assume that we are all Esquires. Thank you.

Mr Speaker: Hon Member, you are right. I think the person conferring the “Esquire” on you does not have that authority to do so. But for me seated here, I can call Azumah Nelson Professor, and nobody can take that away from me.

Yes?

3:14 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I just need guidance from you with regard to “esquire”. What is the meaning of “esquire”? Mr Speaker, I may be wrong, but my understanding is that “esquire” means “mister” and anybody can be called a “mister”. So, Mr Speaker, if you can help us with the meaning or implication of the word “esquire”—My little understanding of “esquire” means “mister”, and even from secondary school, one can be addressed as a “mister”. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: I am not learned in Latin—[*Laughter*]. At the time it was used, it conveyed a meaning, and that is why it was sparingly given and accorded to people. It is not like how today you say “mister” and so everybody is esquire. I think this is the printer’s devil, so the Clerks-at-the-Table, kindly draw the attention of the Office of Chamber Reporting to do the right thing—

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker?

The Speaker: Sorry.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. It is just a minor one, but I think we should have a look at it. I would also let my First Deputy Minority Whip know that, of course, traditionally “esquire” was just used for people who did not have anything attached to their names. But in contemporary times, “esquire” refers to someone who is learned or is called to the Bar in the American system.

Mr Speaker, column three of the *Official Report* for Wednesday, 22nd October, the second line —

The Speaker: Let me put the question on the *Official Report* of 21st October, 2025 before we go to that of 22nd October, 2025.

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Tuesday, 21st October, 2025 as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

We now go to Wednesday, 22nd October, 2025. Yes, any corrections?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I will seek your guidance first before I come to the correction. When we go to Order 48 (4) of our Standing Orders, it says:

“A copy of the Parliamentary Debate shall be sent to each Member as soon as practicable after the conclusion of each sitting.

(5) The House shall correct and adopt the Votes and Proceedings and the Official Report of a previous sitting as the true record of proceedings.”

Mr Speaker, we have had challenges as to exactly when we receive this *Official Report* and at what point we review and approve it. In many instances, when they become bulky and we receive them a few hours before Parliament sits, at times two hours before Parliament sits, it becomes difficult for Members to review the entire document and pass comment; I will speak for myself. Particularly when later we review it and there are some key issues that, if given the opportunity, we would have wanted to correct, but by the time we realise, it would have lapsed. So, I need your guidance just so we know that if we receive the *Official Reports* — I understand previously, it would have been put in our pigeon holes for at least a day or so, so Members can take time to review and then comment. But these days, we receive them a couple of minutes or hours before Sitting and it does not help so much. So, I will seek your direction and guidance there.

But let me go to column three, and as I said, it is a very minor one. In the second line, “... write to inform the Table accordingly ...” “because”. The “B” was missing and I know it is a typo, so could they correct that? Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Table Office, kindly take note.

Hon Member, there is a lot of history to this, partly because we are doing this manually and we are transiting into the electronic era. So, copies of the *Official Reports* will be sent to your various emails so that wherever you are, you can work on them before we sit. As of now, we are having a challenge.

Initially, Ghana Publishing Corporation was part of the Parliament of Ghana; so it was the publishing wing of the House. They had professional skilled workforce that were well taken care of, and they were producing them until we had the intervention of the coup d'état of 1966. From then, the coup d'état of 1972 jeopardised the future of Ghana Publishing Corporation, and it was taken away from Parliament. It is now operating as part of the — I do not know whether it is the subvented organisation— But that has caused a lot of damage to Parliament as an institution.

So, since 1993, we have been struggling to establish a well-equipped, well resourced, well trained and motivated staff. They stay throughout until the next morning here. When you close from Sitting, they stay here in the night to make sure that all these things

are done before the next Sitting. So, there was a 24-Hour Economy being run here already, long before the announcement of the 24-Hour Economy policy. So, please bear with the office.

The other aspect is that we now buy the Bills from Ghana Publishing Corporation. We work on the Bills, pass them into law, and they are assented to by the President, sent and gazetted by Ghana Publishing Corporation, then Ghana Publishing Corporation sells the Bills. The moneys are not sent to Parliament; they are put in the Consolidated Fund. But we buy the Bills, so we spend a lot of money, even when we are going to pass laws for the good people of Ghana. We are not giving back. When we are budgeting for some of these things, people think that the budget of Parliament is for the benefit of Members of Parliament. Lack of information is the cause of all this.

So, we have to come out with our advocacy and work on these things for people to understand that it is for their own good and not for the benefit of those of you who have fortunately been given the mandate to be here, including my good self. So please, this is part of the challenges. We will soon surmount them. We are introducing a lot of Information Technology (IT), and very soon, you will be getting them earlier than what pertains now.

Please, any further corrections? Yes?

Dr Mahama: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Column 38, the fifth paragraph, line 6, and with your permission, the

word there is “know”, but I use the word “note”, “It is so unfortunate to note that ...”. I am just asking that the Office of Chamber Reporting replaces “know” with “note”.

The Speaker: Yes, Office of Chamber Reporting, kindly take note of that. It is at column 38 of the *Official Report* of Wednesday, 22nd October, 2025.

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Wednesday, 22nd October, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

3:24 p.m.

Hon Members, we would move to item numbered 6, which is Questions.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Rt Hon Speaker, the Minister for Roads and Highways is here and ready to take the Questions.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister, kindly take your proper seat. We want to start with the first Question, Question numbered 387. It stands in the name of Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin, the Member of Parliament for Effutu. I am aware that he is out of jurisdiction.

Yes, First Deputy Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 88 (3). The Member is not available at the moment, and with

your permission, he has authorised me to ask the Question on his behalf.

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Ordinarily, I would not ask for an authority note, but because it is Hon Habib Iddrisu, I insist on seeing an authority note.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, if you read the Standing Order, it does not state that we should provide authority note, and there was no ‘shall’ there. It is ‘may’ which is used, and for that matter, Mr Speaker can give me the authorisation.

Majority Leader, I am your younger brother so sometimes—[*Laughter*]

The Speaker: Hon Members, Order 88 (3) says that,

“In the absence of the Member, any other Member so authorised may, with the prior permission of the Speaker, ask the Question.”

So, it is not an authority note, but you must get the authorisation of the person who actually filed the Question which is admitted and published. The ‘may’ is not referring to the Speaker, it is referring to the Member who is rising to ask the Question for and on behalf of the original Member of Parliament who filed the Question.

That is my understanding of the rule.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it says, ‘so authorised’, he has to show that he was ‘so authorised’. The Rt Hon Speaker is to grant you the permission to ask the Question but you must be ‘so authorised’. So, evidence of the authorisation is needed. Because Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader asked me to ask the Question on his behalf. I was about to rise up—[*Laughter*]—and ask for permission, when he rose up and indicated that he was also authorised. So, we need to establish who was actually authorised because I am also claiming that I was so authorised.

The Speaker: There is a much difference between evidence and the weight on which you put on the evidence. The evidence could be documentary; it could be oral. And depending on the judge—I am not a judge here, I am presiding. I will now put what weight I want on the evidence.

Since you are Hon Members, people of honour, my discretion will weigh in your favour, unless otherwise proven. And so, when you get up and say that you have been authorised or you have the authority of a Member to ask a Question on his behalf, I just will apply the *omnia* rule and allow you to ask the Question.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko — *rose*

The Speaker: Yes?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, the issue of prior approval in Order 88 (3) has popped up a couple of times in your absence. With your interpretation or explanation, it says,

“...any other Member so authorised may, with the prior permission of the Speaker, ask the Question.”

Mr Speaker, I want to find out, is the prior permission of the Speaker mandatory? Because if the burden is on the Member, who may ask, and I take “with the prior permission” off, it will read, any other Member so authorised may ask the Question. I just want to seek guidance, since we have had different approaches and direction from the Chair in terms of this, is the prior permission of the Speaker, when someone is “so authorised”, mandatory? If the Speaker so wishes, he can say that he does not permit you so that Question is not asked. I need your direction on that.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, it has happened. If you get up, you are asking for my permission to ask a Question so you have not asked the Question. Until I grant you the permission, you cannot ask the Question. So, when you seek the permission, I can say no, I would not grant you that permission. I want the Member himself to come to ask the Question. So, the Question may be deferred to another day for the Member to be present for good reason, to ask the Question.

Sometimes, some questions are constituency specific. Sometimes some skills and professionalism come into play when you are asking the Question. And the follow-up questions which we refer to as supplementary questions, are

also important. So, you do not want to treat some questions in a very cavalier manner. And so, the Speaker is given that authority; to either permit or not permit. That is where the ‘prior’ comes in. If I say no, I do not grant you the leave, you cannot ask the Question. And that is prior to asking the Question. That is the interpretation and that has been the practice for some time now. I did not know you were having some difficulty in clarifying this provision.

Anyway, Hon Member, you are granted leave. I know how close you are to him so I hope that you would ask the right supplementary questions.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I think your guidance will help us a lot moving forward. Because many of our first-timers, or many Members will just get up, quote Order 88 (3) and read the Question. But after you made the application, you need to sit down until the Speaker gives you such authorisation.

Mr Speaker, to draw the Majority Leader’s attention, that the Minority Leader is out of the jurisdiction on official work, the Deputy Minority Leader is also out on a committee work, and the Minority Chief Whip is an election observer in Tanzania. So, at the moment, I am in charge. *[Hear! Hear!]*. I am the next in command.

Mr Speaker, it is not in your case where you are ‘number 3’ or sometimes ‘number 2’. I am in charge. *[Laughter]*

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, in view of this development, I may have to leave the Chamber so that he can deal with his counterparts. *[Laughter]*

3:34 p.m.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ROADS AND HIGHWAYS

Causes of the slowed down works on the Kasoa – Winneba road

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu *on behalf of Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (NPP — Effutu):* Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to ask the Question on behalf of the Member of Parliament for Effutu. I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways why construction works on the Kasoa – Winneba road has slowed down, causing significant inconvenience to motorists.

Thank you.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

Background

The Kasoa – Winneba Road is a critical segment of the national road (N1) which links the Volta/Greater Accra and the Central/Western regions.

Current Programme

The road has been awarded under the contracts titled;

- Rehabilitation and upgrading of Akoti Junction - Winneba Roundabout (km 0.00 - 12.00) - Lot 1,
- Rehabilitation and upgrading of Akoti Junction - Winneba Roundabout (km 12.00 - 30.00) - Lot 2,
- Rehabilitation and Upgrading of Kasoa – Winneba Road (30.0km) LOT 1A, Construction of Interchanges at Sapato (km 1+500), Buduburam (km 3+ 200) Awutu Breku (km 7+ 200), Akoti (km 9+800) and 3no. Footbridges,
- Rehabilitation and Upgrading of Kasoa – Winneba Road (30.0km) LOT 2A, Construction of Interchanges at km 15+900 (Onion Market); km 18+900 (Potsin); Twin River Bridge at Km 22+900 (Okyerko); and 3no. Footbridges’.

The contracts commenced on 29th March, 2024 for completion by 29th March, 2027. The progress of works is estimated at 57 per cent, 52 per cent, 70 per cent and 69 per cent physical completion respectively.

The Contractors are on site and works are ongoing and on schedule

Mr Speaker, as a matter of record, the contractor has never stopped work and has never slowed down. The contractor is one of the few that had kept working despite the situation we had in the country prior to the election. So, the contractor has never stopped work or slowed down.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: No, Mr Speaker, I do not have any supplementary question.

The Speaker: Yes, thank you so much.

Hon Member, do you have a supplementary question?

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I am very much particular about this road because it leads to the Western Region where I am from. There is a lot of problems in terms of traffic and lack of road signs on the road, particularly in the evening. When one drives, there is no direction from the contractor as to which road one is supposed to use and it is all messy. So, I just want to find out from the Hon Minister the steps being taken to ensure that in the midst of the construction in these stages, the road is properly directed for motorists so that we do not encounter the midnight accidents and the challenges in terms of the heavy traffic that occurs on that particular corridor.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, my Colleague has made a very important point. It is the responsibility of contractors to make sure all safety measures are taken even while they are working within existing rights of way. So, now that the Hon Member has raised it, we will draw the attention of the contractor to improve all activities that

will ensure that while they are carrying out the works, the public safety is prioritised.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, thank you. I would like to ask the Minister how much they owe the contractor and how much they plan to pay the contractors this year?

Mr Agbodza: I would have said that we owe him exactly how much we owed before President Mahama took office but I do not have the exact figure. However, we still owe him that much of money.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Hon Minister, just by way of clarity, whether the dualisation of Accra – Cape Coast Road is part of the plan of this Government or the previous one?

3:40 p.m. — [HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR ANDREW ASIAMAHO AMOAKO, IN THE CHAIR]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Let us now turn to the Question numbered 294 which stands in the name of Hon Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth, a Member for Okere.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, there was a supplementary question which the Hon Minister was about to answer before you took the Chair.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, this forms part of the Abidjan – Lagos corridor. So, we are supposed to work on the road from Aflao all the way to Elubo so, we are doing them in segments: from Kasoa – Winneba, Winneba to Mankessim, all the way to Cape Coast and to the Western Region are part of this. However, not all of them are under contract at the same time but this particular section is under contract.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. We can now turn to the Question numbered 294. Hon Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth, the Member for Okere.

Resumption of Dawu and Abiriw town Roads

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth (NPP — Okere): Mr Speaker, I rise to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the contractor working on the following roads which have stalled will resume work: (i) Dawu town (ii) Abiriw town.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, thank you.

Background

Dawu and Abiriw Townships are located in the Okere District of the Eastern Region.

Current Programme

The town roads have been awarded under the contract titled “Addendum No. 1: Rehabilitation of New Tafo Town roads, Kukurantumi Town roads (15.42

km), Adukrom-Abirew road (5.5km) and Adukrom Town roads (4.31km) and others (4.73km)”.

The project was awarded on 27th January, 2023, for 30 calendar months. The contract commenced on 13th July, 2023, for completion by 12th January, 2026.

The project is at 82 per cent physical completion.

The contractor is currently not on site, and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor to return to site to complete all the outstanding works.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Member, any further questions?

3:44 p.m.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, I would like to thank the Hon Minister for the Answer. Except that, since he attributed the contractor abandoning site to delays in payment, I want to find out from him the timeline so that we can estimate when the contractor will come back to site.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, this honourable House approved an amount of money as payment for arrears owed contractors in the 2025 Budget

Statement. Government has since commenced disbursement towards the retirement of some of those debts.

As I previously said, Mr Speaker, with the GoG section alone, we owe over GH¢21 billion; Road Fund, GH¢8 billion; and Cocoa Roads, over GH¢7 billion. I must say that within the last two weeks, Government has paid over GH¢5 billion towards the payment of those debts. But we are talking of over GH¢30 billion, so obviously, it will not be surprising that some contractors are yet to be paid. But even the GH¢5 billion would appear to be the biggest ever single payment by any government to contractors at a particular time, and I think President Mahama's Government needs to be commended.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Okere?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the people of Dawu and Abiriw would want some assurances from the Hon Minister as to the efforts to bring back the contractor because this road plays a major role in the lives of the people. Most of our durbar grounds and gathering activities are along our main road, so every weekend, there are diversions. And due to the conditions of the road, these diversions create a lot of challenges for us, as well as the new site. So, I want some assurances for my people in Dawu and Abiriw. Mr Speaker, when I mention Abiriw, the Hon Minister would understand that there is a special relationship between Okere and Adaklu, and this is Abiriw and Dawu we are talking about.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, we will do whatever is possible to make sure that we bring the contractor back to site. I must commend the contractor. He has done 82 per cent of the work, and I would not classify this contractor as one of the people who abandoned work. Having done 82 per cent of the work, he has done well. So, we encourage him to come back while we also work towards paying part of what we owe him.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, let us now turn to Question 295, which stands in the name of the same person, Hon Member for Okere, Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth.

Hon Member, you may take Question 295.

Resumption of the Construction on the Konko-Asasekorkor-Kwamoso Road

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth (NPP—Okere): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when construction on the Konko-Asasekorkor-Kwamoso Road will resume.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza): Mr Speaker, the road mentioned by my Hon Colleague was awarded under a project titled "Rehabilitation of Konko-Asasekorkor-Kwamoso Feeder Road, 10.6 kilometres"

The contract, which was awarded on the 19th of August 2021, commenced on the 22nd of September, 2021, for completion on the 22nd August, 2024. The progress of work is estimated at 84 per cent. The contractor is currently not on site due to delay in payment for works done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Minister for this Answer. Except that, in all humility and respect, Mr Speaker, from my checks as of August, the contract had been abrogated on the Asasekorkor-Kwamoso Road. So, I would like to find out from the Hon Minister—Normally, when these things happen, there is some repackaging. There seems to be some discrepancies in the information the Hon Minister is providing and probably what has been happening on the ground.

If the Hon Minister could clarify that for us, respectfully.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the extent of completion of this project is 84 per cent, and the contractor not being on site is due to delays in payment. I am not aware that the contractor has officially been asked to stop work. All I am saying is, whatever it takes to bring the contractor back on site, it is our responsibility to make sure that happens, whether it is the same contractor or not. I am not aware of the official termination of this contract.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Maybe we will follow up on that information. While at it, there is another road sandwiched in between the Konko-Asasekorkor-Kwamoso Road, which is Asenema to Kurutiase Road, that has been tarred, but it is left with some four kilometres of road from Kurutiase, Abenawia, Mankrado, Beware to Bewasi. Under the same Okere-Adaklu relationship, if the Hon Minister could be kind enough that in assessing the Konko-Asasekorkor-Kwamoso Road, that one can be added, so that we have a complete stretch of road, respectfully.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the request is duly acknowledged and action will be taken.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am jumping to Question 297 which still stands in the name of the Hon Member for Okere, Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth.

So, Hon Member, you may take your Question now.

Completion of the Aseseeso-Abonse-Agomeda Road

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth (NPP—Okere): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the Aseseeso-Abonse-Agomedea Road will be completed.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza): Mr Speaker, the road, as mentioned by my Hon Colleague, was awarded under a contract titled “Upgrading of Aseseeso-Abonse-Agomeda Feeder Road,” 5.70

kilometres. The contract was awarded on 27th May, 2024 for completion by 25th July, 2025. The overall progress of work is 78 per cent. The contractor is currently on site and works are progressing.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, this road leads to one of our traditional communities, Abonse, which also used to host the slave market within the Greater Eastern Accra Plains. Because of their location, they are a bit departed from the main Okere township. Just two months ago, the contractor moved all his equipment to an ongoing road in the Yilo-Krobo District, so I want to plead with the Hon Minister—The contractor had always been on site, as the Hon Minister indicated, until just two months ago. It has become a source of worry for the community. If the Hon Minister could talk to the contractor, at least, to bring some equipment so that the community would see that work on the road is ongoing, we would be very grateful.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the point is well-made and taken. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Minister.

Let me now come back to Question 296, and it stands in the name of Hon Member for Tema Central, Mr Charles Forson.

Hon Member, you have the floor

Return of Contractor Assigned to Community Eleven (11) State Fishing Corporation Enclave Inner Roads

Mr Charles Forson (NPP—Tema Central): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the contractor assigned to the Community Eleven (11) State Fishing Corporation enclave inner roads will return to the site.

3:54 p.m.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza): Mr Speaker, the Community 11 State Fishing Corporation enclave inner roads were awarded under the contract entitled “Drainage works along Community Eleven (11) Rose – Sharon Road and selected links”.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Background

Community Eleven (11) State Fishing Enclave is located in the Tema Central Constituency of the Tema Metropolitan Assembly. The Department of Urban Roads adopted stage construction strategy to improve mobility within the enclave.

Current Programme

The Community Eleven (11) State Fishing Enclave Inner Roads were

awarded under the contract titled “Drainage Works along Community Eleven (11) Rose – Sharon Road and selected links (4.5km)”. The contract was awarded on the 21st August 2023, for the construction of drains. Works commenced on 4th September 2023 for completion by 4th January 2025.

Under the project, 4.5km of drains of various sizes were constructed along selected local roads in Community Eleven (11), namely: Flamingo Drive, Sparrow Close, Sunbird Lane, Akasanoma Drive, Virgo A & B Lanes, Sand Piper Close, Parrot Close, Chiropractic Street, Eagle Close, Eagle Close Link, Nightingale & Pidgeon Links, and 5th Avenue. The project is completed.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies have been carried out on the road for consideration under the 2026 Budget, subject to the availability of funds.

Mr Speaker, this is like this because if you remember, I said that what was awarded was just for the drains and that has been completed.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Forson, any further questions?

Mr Forson: Thank you, Mr Speaker. The follow-up is constituency-specific. With regard to Community 9 Light Industrial Area, the drains, everything has been done. What we are left with is bitumen and then the overlay. I wish to

ask the Hon Minister if it is possible for him to give some assurances of when the contractor will return to site.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It is a constituency-specific question, please.

Mr Forson: Mr Speaker, he is aware of where I am talking about; the Community 9 Light Industrial Area.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, indeed, I am aware of the situation at Community 9, but the Question that was filed was about Community 11. So, if the Hon Member wants details about Community 9, he can file a Question and I would be here to respond to their specifics.

Mr Forson: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, shall we turn to Question 371, which stands in the name of Hon Samuel Awuku, MP for Akuapem North.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh: Mr Speaker, I stand on Order 88(3) to seek your leave to ask the Question for and on behalf of Mr Samuel Awuku, Member of Parliament for Akuapem North

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, leave is granted. Please go on.

Curbing Road Accidents and Casualties at the Tetteh Quarshie Memorial Hospital

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh on behalf of Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Akuapem North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways

the measures the Ministry is implementing to curb the rampant road accidents and casualties that have been occurring at the Tetteh Quarshie Memorial Hospital over the past few years.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Background

The Tetteh Quarshie Memorial Hospital is located along the Accra–Koforidua Highway (N4) at Mampong-Akuapem in the Eastern Region. It is a major health facility serving several communities within the Akuapem North Municipality and beyond.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies for road safety will be carried out on the road to determine the appropriate traffic management measures for consideration under the 2026 Budget, subject to the availability of funds.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any further questions?

Mr Ayeh: Mr Speaker, just by direction, the Member of Parliament wants to know if there are some timelines to this effect. That is all.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Yes, Mr Speaker the immediate timeline is the fact that the engineering studies would be prepared for consideration under the 2026 Budget Statement which is just few weeks away.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Let us turn to Question 372, Hon Ayeh, you may take that as well. It stands in the name of Hon Samuel Awuku.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh on behalf of Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Akuapem North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the urgent infrastructural measures being implemented to ensure safe road crossing for the students of Mampong Akuapem Senior Technical School for the Deaf, given the high-speed road they use to access facilities on the adjoining campus.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Background

The Mampong-Akuapem Senior Technical School for the Deaf, located in the Akuapem North Municipality of the Eastern Region, is a specialised educational institution that provides technical and vocational training for students with hearing impairments from various parts of the country.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering design studies for road safety will be carried out on the road to determine the appropriate traffic management measures for consideration under the 2026 Budget, subject to the availability of funds.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker. The Member of Parliament only seeks to highlight the fact that the circumstance of these students who are deaf or dumb, and looking at the high speed around the area and adjoining campuses because they need to cross from one campus to the other. The Member of Parliament is just pleading with the Minister to see how best they can facilitate some of these assessments so the students can have some reliefs, particularly with the roads they use.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. This does not need just a request.

Hon Member, take Question 382 again on behalf of Mr Samuel Awuku.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh on behalf of Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Akuapem North): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when

the Adawso – Mangoase – Tinkong road will be completed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Background

The Adawso - Mangoase - Tinkong feeder road is 24.5km long. It is located in the Akuapim North Municipality of the Eastern Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Adawso-Mangoase-Tinkong feeder road was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Adawso-Mangoase-Tinkong feeder Road (24.50km)” on 7th November, 2024 for completion by 17th December, 2026.

The overall progress of works is estimated at 45 per cent physical completion. The Contractor is currently on site and works are ongoing.

Mr Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I want to thank the Hon Minister for ably responding to the questions for Hon Samuel Awuku. No further questions.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Hon Members, we would take the last Question from the Hon Member for Atebubu/Amantin, Mr Sanja Nanja?

Mr Vincent Oppong Asamaoh: Mr Speaker, I would like to seek your leave to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, leave is granted.

4:04 p.m.

Mr Vincent Oppong Asamoah *on behalf of Mr Sanja Nanja (NDC — Atebubu/Amantin):* Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways why the contractor working on Atebubu-Kwame Danso Road has abandoned site?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the Atebubu–Kwame Danso Road is a strategic corridor within the Bono East Region, linking the Atebubu-Amantin Municipal capital (Atebubu) to the Sene West District capital (Kwame Danso).

The road has been awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Atebubu - Kwame Danso - Kwadwokrom Road (km 0 - 35.0) - Lot 1”. The contract commenced on 19th December, 2024, for completion by 18th December, 2026. The progress of works is estimated at 20.65 per cent physical completion. The Contractor is currently not on site due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete all outstanding works.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any further questions?

Mr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Hon Minister if he is aware that it is one of the most dangerous roads we have in the country in terms of armed robbery? Because the roads are not good, there is always armed robbery on that road.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is it a question or what?

Mr Asamoah: Yes. Mr Speaker, it is related to—Mr Speaker, he said the Contractor will be—I want him to prioritise that road because it is one of the most dangerous roads we have in the country in terms of armed robbery. So, I would like to ask the Hon Minister how soon the contractor will come back to site?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, indeed we prioritise all public roads and endeavour to improve them, including this particular road. We will continue to make all the efforts to ensure that the contractor returns to site to complete the work and to reduce the unfortunate situation as described by my Hon Colleague.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will bring Question time to a close. On behalf of the House, let me thank the Hon Minister for Roads and Highways for attending upon the House to respond to Questions from Hon Members.

Hon Minister, we are grateful to you and you are hereby discharged.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture is not available, but if you would grant leave, we will vary the order of Business; skip Statements and then start with the Presentation of Papers. With your indulgence, if the Hon Minister for Education can lay the Papers on the item numbered 8 on behalf of the Hon Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr. Speaker, we do not have any difficulty. He can do it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you may do us the honours.

PAPER

By the Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) on behalf of the Minister for Food and Aquaculture—

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture Development for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, let us take the item numbered 14, Consideration

Stage of the Ghana Scholarship Authority Bill, 2025.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we can take that item, but before the Consideration Stage, we did indicate to the Hon Majority Leader when he was presenting the Business Statement that sometime this week, we should be able to have a Committee of the Whole or a Closed Sitting. There are a lot of issues that we need to look at and we would need the presence of the Hon Minister for Finance or his Deputy.

Mr Speaker, if the Majority Leader could give an indication of the time, we can have Closed Sitting tomorrow. But we need the presence of either the Hon Minister for Finance or his Deputy, because the matters that we are going to discuss concerns things that they need to deal with. So, let us know the time for tomorrow before the Mace is tilted for the Consideration Stage.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leader of the House?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, last week, indications were given that we may need to have the Committee of the Whole.

If we really want the Hon Minister for Finance, it would be difficult because he is out of the jurisdiction. I have not been able to reach the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance to be able to confirm his availability tomorrow. So, if we want the Minister of Finance or his

deputy, I would have to reach out to them and get back to the House. I would have preferred that we have this tomorrow, Thursday, after Sitting or during Sitting somehow. So, why not wait till tomorrow for us to check with the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, if he is available, then we can quickly notify everyone, so that we can have the Closed Sitting tomorrow.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly indulge me to turn to page 5, the item numbered 14, Ghana Scholarship Authority Bill, 2025 at the Consideration Stage.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE Ghana Scholarship Authority Bill, 2025

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Chairman of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs, I will need your attention. The Chairman of the Committee on Education will lead us in the consideration.

Yes, Chairman of the Committee on Education?

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, we are still doing some consultations so for clauses 4 and 5, we will not touch them now. We would start from clause 17.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, we are holding on with clause 4 and clause 5 for further consultations. Very well.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, it is an appeal I want to make to the Hon Minister, the Chairman of the Committee and to the Table Office. We know this Bill started last Meeting, and unfortunately, we do not have copies with us. Checking on the electronic device, it is also not uploaded. So, if there are some few copies around that can be made available to us, so that we can follow and then make some inputs when necessary.

4:14 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we are making efforts to get them copies, but his concerns are legitimate. *[Pause]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the understanding is that we have worked up to clause 17, only that we flagged clauses 4 and 5, but we will still revisit them. So, we are continuing from clause 17.

Very well.

Clause 17—Secretary to the Board.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, I beg to move clause 17, *delete* and *insert* the following:

“Secretary to the Board 17. (1) The Board shall designate the head of the Legal Department as secretary to the Board.

(2) The Secretary shall hold office on terms and conditions

specified in the letter of appointment.

(3) The Secretary shall

- (a) arrange the business of the Board;
- (b) record and keep the minutes of the Board; and
- (c) perform any other function that the Board may assign.”

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 17 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clauses 18 and 19 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 20—Funds of the Authority.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, clause 20—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on. Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, in clause 19(1), we are establishing an Internal Audit Unit in accordance with Act 921, 2016. And yet in 19(2), we are saying that the Head of that unit will be in accordance with the Internal Audit Agency Act, 2003 (Act 658).

Now, my difficulty is that we need to introduce Act 658 also in clause 1, so that the Head, who will be appointed in

accordance with Act 658, will be given gravamen in clause 2, because we completely sidestepped Act 658 in clause 1. We are establishing the Internal Audit Unit oblivious of the existence of the Internal Audit Agency Act. So, we need to introduce this law also in clause 1. So if the drafters can just accommodate it in clause 1.

No, we could do so in accordance with both. Especially when we are saying that in clause 2, the Head of the unit will be appointed in accordance with the PFM Act.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Chairman of the Committee, are you in line with what the Majority Chief Whip is proposing?

Mr Dafeamekpor: All right, my submission is that in clause 1, we are urging the House to adopt the clause that says “we are establishing an Internal Audit Unit in accordance with the PFM Act 2016 (Act 921)”. Now, if that subsists, then we cannot say in clause 2 that the Head of that unit will be appointed in accordance with another law, which is the Internal Audit Agency Act, Act 658, without first saying that the establishment of the unit will also be in accordance with the law under which the Head will be appointed.

There are two existing legislations that we are struggling to comply with. So it is proper that we introduce the 2003 law in 19(1), just to accommodate it there. That is the establishment provision. Then the Head of the unit,

which is established under that law, will also be in accordance with the 2003 law.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Minister?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, in order to respond legally and appropriately to the Majority Chief Whip, I will refer to Section 83 of the Public Financial Management Act, which provides that there shall be “a covered entity, and that covered entity shall have an Internal Audit Unit.” If that is so, then he should only insist on an abundance of caution because reference is made to the establishment of “an Internal Audit Unit.” So this is the creation of the unit in accordance with the Public Financial Management Act. That is Ghana's basic and fundamental law on fiscal management.

Mr Speaker, once it provides, and I read,

83. “(1) A covered entity shall have an Internal Audit Unit.

(2) The head of the Internal Audit Unit shall report administratively to the Principal Spending Officer and functionally to the Audit Committee of that covered entity”.

So this is what is provided for the PFM Act.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, you have relaxed the rules. —[*Laughter*]

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, he is behaving typically as someone from Tolon, and the MP for Tolon. A typical Tolon man —[*Laughter*]. The Hon Members for Nalerigu and Savelugu know what I mean.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, I have been informed by the drafters that this is a standard format that has been adopted.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we legislate to reform. Let me quote the Internal Audit Agency Act. It is also a substantive legislation formulated by this House. So my problem is that we are introducing in 19(1) that we are setting up the Internal Audit Unit only in accordance with Act 921, 2016, when there is a substantive legislation governing the Internal Audit Agency.

So, all I am saying is that, we should be able to introduce the Internal Audit Agency Act, 2003, the Act 658, also in 19(1), so that the Head of that unit that we are appointing under 19(2) is substantially in accordance with the 2003 law will be proper.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, let me refer that to the drafters. We will look at it and see how best we can couch it. So let us turn to clause 20.

Clause 20 — Funds of the Authority.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: For clause 20, there is an advertised amendment that the Committee would like to abandon and to further amend or request the deletion of paragraph b, 2 per cent of the total oil revenue. I so move.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Come again. Hold on. There are two proposed amendments that have been advertised. So, are you abandoning the two proposed amendments? Only the first one? All right.

04:24 p.m.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, it is a Cabinet policy decision not to earmark oil revenue for the purpose of source of funds for the Authority. Arguably, as a sponsor of the Bill when I was articulating it—I hope you would indulge me just to put it on the record. For the two-and-half per cent, it was my contemplation that in future, Ghana could have a Scholarship and Bursaries Authority so that this dedicated money will be used to administer bursaries and scholarship. Being the Minister for Education, the most impactful initiative of President Mahama under his “Reset Agenda” has been the “No Fees Stress Policy” and no fees for persons with disability. It was my thinking that we could earmark for the purpose of dealing with this in the future. But probably when we see the operation of this law, we would come back in the future.

But Cabinet has advised that I stand down the amendment of two per cent of total revenue. However, my thinking was to earmark it so that we do not just fund

the scholarship, but also create a Scholarship and Bursaries Authority for the future while recognising that the state as of today owes millions of dollars in scholarship. In the United States of America (USA) alone, we owe over US\$40 million, and in the United Kingdom, over £20 million. We would have to rely on budget. That may mean that we may disappoint a number of students who are on scholarship.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right. Let me call the Member of Parliament for Okere.

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth: Thank you Mr Speaker, and I also want to thank the Hon Minister for clarity. Mr Speaker, my issue has to do with clause 20 (d) and (e). One is on loans — *[Interruption]*. We are still on (b)? All right. I thought because the Hon Member was making an amendment to delete it—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Walewale?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I would want to differ from the sponsor of the Bill in the sense that if we look at this whole clause, the proposed paragraph he seeks to delete is the only measurable funding source for the scholarship programme. The rest are to the discretion of people. There are no numbers attached to it. This is the only funding source—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, are you listening to him?

Dr Mahama: This is the only funding source that is very concrete and measurable, by which can determine how much is coming to the Scholarship Fund. The rest is at the discretion of the Executive. Mr Speaker, if one is establishing a fund, one important element to the establishment is the funding source. If there is no funding source that one can clearly place their hands on, then one better not establish it. And I think that even though this is coming from the Executive, this House with the power to make law would have to insist on very clear, measurable funding source. Otherwise, we are just making a law without the efficacy of that law.

Mr Speaker, I propose to the sponsors of this Bill that even if the two per cent is something that they think is a burden on the oil revenues of the country, we could propose a very lower percentage. Using the oil resource of the country to educate our people is a very good investment. There is no better use of our money than to use it to educate the sons and daughters of Mother Ghana. I do not know why Cabinet would take such a decision to drop this rather laudable proposal.

Mr Speaker, I will urge this House that at least one per cent of the oil revenue of the country should be used. Otherwise, we cannot determine where the rest will come from. Mr Speaker, I so submit.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, thank you.

Let me listen to Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, once the Hon Minister has abandoned and actually asked for it to be deleted, I would not want to make any argument towards it. However, from where my Brother, Dr Kabiru Mahama, is coming from, this is a scholarship fund. It is a subset of the general education fund which GETFund and the rest are supposed to take care of. I think we should be more interested in making money available for the totality of education. So, if we commit as much as a percent or two, specifically for scholarship—What is the percentage of Ghanaians? If we look at who the beneficiaries are—Let me leave that and rather go to 20 (c)—Subclause (b) has been deleted? All right.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me give this to the Chairman of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs.

Mr Shaibu Mahama: I am exceedingly grateful. I do not think we should split hairs on this provision. If we look at clause 20(a), whether it is 10 per cent, 19 per cent or 100 per cent, it will still be approved by this House. Clause 20(a) says that, “...moneys approved by Parliament”. It is omnibus enough to cover all the speculations that we are contemplating here. I think that the deletion is in the right direction. The fact that we will tie ourselves up to two per cent in here, it could be more, if Parliament gives approval for that. We will take that off and leave clause 20(a),

which gives an omnibus approval for Parliament. At any rate, Mr Speaker, what moneys could be paid to anybody without Parliamentary approval? That is why approval has to be sought from Parliament.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Kpandai?

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Mr Speaker, I think that we all appreciate the explanation that my good Friend, Mr Shaibu Mahama has given. We are all interested in this Bill because it is about scholarships. As the Memorandum to the Bill states, this was established somewhere in the 1960s. It is something that our grandparents thought about and brought this into fruition. It is up to us to make sure that this works. It is a feather in the Minister's cap because this is the first time we are coming out with such a comprehensive document to guide this scholarship secretariat.

Mr Speaker, we all agree with the Minister because it is a policy from Cabinet, and we cannot be debating Cabinet policies. However, it is in our interest as Ghanaians that if we are doing something, we must try and do it well. If the two per cent is even higher, we are talking about oil revenues, it would have been best if we had some components so reliable that this particular— Even the GETFund formula—That is why I was saying that if we look at what Mr Shaibu Mahama said, that moneys approved by Parliament is omnibus enough, what is the use of a percentage of money from GETFund? What is the use of it?

4:34 p.m.

It is omnibus enough, so let us delete everything, so that we just leave “moneys approved by Parliament”. It is because it is not enough that sometimes we come out with some kind of funding to support the Ghana Scholarship Secretariat. So, we agree that it is a matter of policy. But maybe like the Hon Minister said, that going forward and in the future, we should be looking at it in a way. We may do politics with it, but at the end of the day, we should look at the quantum of money that the Hon Minister is talking about. We are indebted when it comes to the Ghana Scholarship Secretariat, so, it is good. We will leave it here; we all know what is going on, then we will go up to other areas. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, Hon Members, I will be inclined to put questions if I see that we are just splitting our hairs on one issue. I will put the question so that the Majority will vote on it. Is that all right? That is the essence of majoritarianism. If on one issue, Dr Mahama thinks a certain way, and Prof Ayensu-Danquah also thinks another way, and it goes on, the only thing we can do is to put it to a vote. So, I think we have understood this. Or Dr Mahama, do you still want to say something?

Dr Mahama: Rightly so, Mr Speaker, I agree. Safe to say that sometimes the majority needs a bit of explanation and convincing. I will just add that when an issue is so contentious like it is, your laxity of time to dilate

more into the issue could convince them. I am not sure they came to this Chamber with their minds cast in stone on these provisions. So, the argument we are raising is to help them and to help us as a country. Mr Speaker, except to say that I agree with you that when it is ongoing, we will put it to a question and then we can vote as such. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, Chairman, let me hear your proposal again.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, we are abandoning the proposed amendments to *delete* clause 20 (b) as well.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, are we deleting “b” entirely?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right. So, now we move to clause 20 (c). Is that the case? Hon Dafeamekpor, are you saying I should put the question? But he says he has abandoned it.

Mr Dafeamekpor: It is a deletion.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It is a deletion?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, we move to clause 20 (c). Let the Chairperson come in, then you come back. Yes, Chairperson?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, amendment proposed. Paragraph (c), *delete* and *insert* the following: “moneys approved by Parliament for scholarships in the Ghana Education Trust Fund”. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there is a proposed amendment to clause 20 (c). Yes?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: There is an omission. It should be “moneys approved by Parliament for scholarships in the Ghana Education Trust Fund formula”.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, that will be the rendition. Very well. So, Hon Members, clause 20 (c). Yes, Hon Member for Odotobri?

Mr Anthony Mmieh: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Looking at clause 20 (a) and (c) as proposed, I really do not see the difference. I see that the (c) is rather being superfluous. I would rather we delete the (c) as proposed and maintain just (a).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Chairman, he is saying that the clause 20 (c) is just a subset of (a). Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, not necessarily. Every money in Ghana, by law, is paid into the Consolidated Fund. Parliament exercises financial oversight over the Budget, and Parliament can, at any time, decide that we are dedicating this amount of money to fix a problem in the country, be it award of a scholarship. Mr Speaker, every year, GETFund comes to this House with its formula. It has been an integral part of the GETFund formula every other year that a minimum allocation is made for scholarships; that has been the practice. So, we are now making it law that a portion of the GETFund formula will be dedicated to scholarships. So, if this is approved, when the formula is presented to Parliament, we would see a budget line, “scholarships”, from GETFund. It may not be enough, but at least it provides a cushion for those in school to be able to do it; a percentage.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Member for Offinso North?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Earlier, I would have agreed to taking out the percentage in the GETFund formula, but unfortunately, we have denied Ghanaian students almost US\$13.5 million by deleting clause 20 (b), the two per cent of oil revenue. Last year, approximately, we had about US\$1.35 billion. By deleting clause 20 (b), we are saying that we are denying our young ones almost US\$13.5 million that we could use to help develop them so that they can take over this nation. So, if we are taking that out, then we cannot assure the young Ghanaians, the youth of

this country that we are putting the percentage of the GETFund money that is coming in, into their education. So, Mr Speaker, either we are bringing the one per cent of the oil revenue and leaving it as has been proposed by the Chairperson, or we will have to put a certain percentage there, because we need to have some —*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, I am making that argument because if we are taking one, we cannot take two away.

That means the argument that was made by the Member of Parliament for Odotobri will stand, because we are saying “moneys approved by Parliament”, then the “money approved by Parliament for scholarships in the GETFUND formula”. We know for sure that there is a percentage of our taxes that is going to GETFund, but we also have to be sure of what percentage is going towards the scholarship. So, there has to be a percentage. If not, Mr Speaker, we may have to —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Did you listen to the Hon Minister?

Dr Asamoah: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Minister is trying to say that over the years, GETFund has been doing that, but GETFund is actually not obliged to do that.

4:44 p.m.

Once we approve this, here, the formula, there will be a budget line dedicated to scholarship. Hon Minister, is that not the argument?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, rightly so.

What our Colleagues should appreciate is that when this scholarship authority is established, it becomes a public entity, and it is entitled to budgetary allocations by the Hon Minister for Finance. In his budget allocation, he can say that he is dedicating an amount of 20 million for the scholarship authority but that has to be approved by Parliament as part of the approval of the budget and appropriation. But the formula is a statutory fund which also comes to Parliament for Parliament to exercise oversight. So, we can have moneys approved by Parliament that takes care of my first argument.

The second is a percentage from the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund). Mr Speaker, we have a problem. There are Ghanaian students abroad who are in their final year, who if we do not get money to pay their fees, will probably have difficulty completing school. We are mindful of that but I said this other bursaries and scholarship authority is futuristic. Mine is that I see no wrong in dedicating a portion of oil revenue to support human resource and human capital. Every country uses human resource.

Mr Speaker, I would come back to this House in the foreseeable immediate future to see if we can establish a scholarship and bursaries authority.

Thank you.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Minister for Education, I would need your attention here.

Mr Speaker, we are making laws and we are trying to make it better. If you look at clause 20 (b), it states, “two per cent of the total oil revenue” but in clause 20 (c), “a percentage of moneys from the Ghana Education Trust Fund determined by the Board”. So, my question and the question my Colleague was trying to establish is that if GETFund brings their formula here, to be determined by the Board—because the Minister in his response said that a percentage from the GETFund formula will be used to fund the scholarship secretariat. What percentage of the GETFund formula?

Assuming the Board decides to say that because you are not specific in passing or making this a law, we are giving you 0.03 per cent which will be insignificant or say that what we are giving or what we have realised in terms of the revenue from GETFund, we are giving you something that is insignificant. The funding part is a very serious component of the entire scholarship secretariat, so if we do not have a dedicated fund of which the oil revenue—even though we have passed that stage, it was very much all right because you know that you are getting some 2 per cent from oil revenue. Other than that, you would pass the law and will not be able to fund it. It will just be there; a white elephant. How do you fund it? So, I think we have to be very specific on that.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Shaibu Mahama?

Mr Shaibu Mahama: Mr Speaker, I think that I tend to agree with the First Deputy Minority Whip. If you check the original renditions, it says, “a percentage of moneys from the Ghana Education Trust Fund determined by the Board.”

Indeed, we saw that the determination by the Board would not hold. It is rather by Parliament. In coming out with the new rendition, we left out a ‘percentage’. So, I think that I will make a further proposal, an amendment, to bring in:

“a percentage of moneys approved by Parliament for the scholarships in the Ghana Education Trust Fund formula.”

I so move.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. It means you have done away with the Board.

Mr S. Mahama: Yes, not by the Board, by Parliament.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Alright, that is the new rendition. Mr Shaibu Mahama, can you come again with the rendition—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have to be guided by a very recent legislation which is the Ghana Medical Trust Fund, Act 2025. That is what we

did. We took money from National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA). The NHIA formula is approved by this House.

So, it is not novel that we take money from a fund that is already established and approved by this House. Now, the argument that we should indicate a percentage, by all means, it will be a percentage. But the wisdom is that when that formula comes to this House, every time we debate it and agree on which percentage should go where. So, we would be caging ourselves into a straitjacket if we determine a certain percentage. I think what we should do is that we should give the mandate, and when they formulate it and give the various categories that they come, then we would determine by the various arguments and debates on the floor. Then we will assign the portions. But if you put it in the legislation, even if they want to increase it, then it means we must come by amendment.

I want us the drafters to look at the Ghana Medical Trust Fund, Act 2025, and use the phrase to tidy this Bill up, then we can make progress. But once the percentage introduced by Mr Shaibu Mahama will not harm the provision, I believe we can carry it. It will be a further amendment to what has been advertised. Then we can make progress.

Mr Speaker, we have a certain situation and we do not want to stay too long so the debate must be brief so that we can make progress and adjourn for the day.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Mahama?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, we are talking about two different things: Ghana Education Trust Fund and Ghana Education Trust Fund formula. These are two different things. If we are making reference to the formula, we cannot put percentage rate and that becomes a problem for this particular Fund. But if you are talking about the Ghana Education Trust Fund, we will need to put a percentage rate. That is why I am saying that if we are conflicting the two, we will get it wrong. The formula is being discussed and is debated by this House so there is nothing concrete about the formula until it comes to this House and debated and all moneys are approved. But for the Fund and the amount that goes into it, it is determined *ab initio*. Because we have passed a law and we are saying that a certain percentage of our revenue taxes should go to the Trust Fund. So, it is determined. We do not want to look at the allocation of that particular percentage to various sectors.

We are proposing that if we delete clause 20 (b), and we are saying that government should approve moneys, then we must be ready to put some percentage of funds that should be drawn from the GETFund to finance this Bill. But if the Hon Member says that a percentage of the formula, it means that when they come and say—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But my Brother, the money that goes to the Fund is the entire money that comes to

this House to determine how it is supposed to be used through the formula. I see it as the same because the money that is coming from the Consolidated Fund to the GETFund is the entire money that will be brought here for us to determine how the formula is supposed to be. So, you would determine how much you should give for scholarship.

4:54 p.m.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, that is exactly what we want to prevent. We have to look at the intent of this Bill. We are collapsing Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) Scholarship Programme. By the enactment of this Bill, we are consolidating and that is what the Bill says. The Bill says that we are consolidating the different scholarship programmes. If that is what the Bill says, then I am basically right.

Mr Speaker, paragraph 4 of the Memorandum reads:

“Furthermore, the multiplicity of public institutions handling or awarding scholarships without collaboration with the Secretariat is another challenge that affects the effectiveness and efficiency of the Secretariat in the performance of its functions. This, in particular affects the responsibility of the Secretariat to report fully and accurately to Government and other stakeholders on all scholarships awarded by public institutions in their country.”

Mr Speaker, that is the import of this Bill, so if I say that by this Bill, the GNPC scholarship cannot go on without

reference to this Bill, I am right. There is money that GNPC would set aside for their programme. Now that money is supposed to then be channelled to this particular fund, and that is what we contemplated in (b) of clause 20. Now we say that delete (b), and I am saying that, once we delete (b), let us refund a certain percentage, and then we would be very concrete with the fund, otherwise, I am afraid, this Bill will be a white elephant.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think the Minister for Education should note that, based on the arguments Dr Mahama has advanced, it is very important and necessary to allocate a percentage of funds, if we want the survival of this Bill. We should not just be thinking about this Parliament. Now this Parliament has a super Majority of 185 plus four independent Members making 189. In the 8th Parliament, if the Speaker had chosen to do business with the Minority, the Minority would have been the Majority even though they would not have had the Executive President. So, if Parliament wants to staff an institution based on its numbers and we are not setting aside a percentage, we can have the powers to do that if we leave the Bill to stand. But we should be able to pass a Bill that will go beyond this Parliament.

So, let us assume there is an Executive President, but the party that holds the Presidency does not have majority in Parliament, and we say the formula and the percentage must be determined by Parliament. If I am in the opposition party and have majority in

Parliament, and I want to staff the Scholarship Bill, I will bring the formula and either give 0.01 per cent or whatever it is. So, it is good that we put a certain percentage to it, so that it will guide us and the Bill will have life moving forward.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I will persuade my Colleagues to appreciate that this is Parliament. The GETFund formula will come to Parliament, and we will make a decision. Under the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921), we ought to do fiscal analysis. How much do we need for scholarship in a particular year? We can decide as a country that, tomorrow we need to train more engineers or medical doctors and that will determine how much Parliament should allocate to support scholarship.

So, when we say a percentage, we are leaving that to Parliament, that whenever the GETFund formula comes before us, mindful of the need of the Scholarship Authority, then we make sure it will be done for that year. We are also minded that the Minister for Finance is doing an overall revision of the Value-Added Tax, which is the source or feed to the GETFund and therefore, when we put a percentage, we may get less than what we require when we need more. So, Colleagues, I think that a percentage is enough. The burden and mandate is still that of Parliament. Then, based on practice, we can improve it over the years.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I agree with the Hon Minister but we have been in this House for some time now and Ministers rarely go by moneys allocated to them. We have all been in this House for some time now. And if we are leaving it this way, it is too discretionary. The formula has always been approved by this Parliament and there has always been some kind of allocation from the formula to Scholarship Secretariat. If we want to go by that way, then I do not see why we should legislate it because it has always been so. Any formula that we bring to this House, there is a portion that goes to the Scholarship Secretariat. I do not know why we are running away from a percentage. The Majority Chief Whip just mentioned the Medical Trust Fund which had a specific percentage. It was there. We never argued this way. Because there was some kind of powers behind it, we never argued. Because we knew it was going to enhance MahamaCares. Because of MahamaCares, we did not talk but rather, we all agreed. But because this one is coming to ‘Ghana Care’, there is a problem. *[Laughter]* Mr Speaker, there should not be a problem.

Mr Speaker, I would want to propose an amendment or I would like to appeal to the Hon Minister and these are two things. If we will flag this particular clause, I will be happy. But if we are not flagging, then I want to make a proposal. We either vote against it or it stands. My proposal is “15 per cent of money

approved by Parliament for scholarships in the Ghana Education Trust Fund formula”. So, put the Question and if we are voted out, we know that we have been voted out but we would have made our case.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, like I said, I think I will be inclined to be putting the Questions as we move on because we have diverse views on any issue that comes before us.

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, there are two things: one, the amendment before us is the further amendment enhanced by the Hon Mahama Shaibu. That is where we are. Now, there is a counter from the Hon Nyindam but in making that counter, he went very unparliamentary. There is no way this Bill that is sponsored by His Excellency John Dramani Mahama’s Government is not meant for Ghana.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You should take things lightly.

Mr Dafeamekpor: No, we will take things lightly but Mr Speaker, if we allow such things to go into the records —*[Interruption]* It is Ghana Care also known as MahamaCares. So, let the record reflect that this Bill is sponsored by Mahama’s Government. So, even though it is MahamaCares, it is still ‘Ghana Care’. Let the record reflect that.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Member, give us the proposed further amendment that you gave. Then I will put the Question on the counter-proposal from Hon Nyindam then we move on.

Mr S. Mahama: Mr Speaker, most grateful. Having listened to the arguments, may I rehash the new rendition?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, give us the new proposed rendition.

Mr S. Mahama: So, Mr Speaker, in clause 20(c), the proposed new amendment should be “a percentage of moneys approved by Parliament for scholarship in the Ghana Education Trust Fund formula.” I so move, Mr Speaker.

5:04 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there is a further proposed amendment to the one advertised on the *Order Paper*.

Mr Nyindam, will you still maintain your counter argument?

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, I have abandoned my proposal. I know tomorrow you will come back to this proposal although I have abandoned it. Because the powers here are very less.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 20 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill

Clause 21—24 ordered to stand part of the Bill

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Before we move to Clause 25, let us turn

to the Speaker’s Gallery. We have guests from Pan-African Parliament and the Committee on Trade, Customs and Immigration. They are five in number and are seated at the Speaker’s Gallery. The first person is Hon Rodney Cloete from Namibia. The second one is Hon Hanna Benkhair from Morocco. The third person is Hon Jonathan Daka from Zambia. The fourth person is Ms Marina Da Trinida from Benin and she is the Clerk to the Committee. And lastly, Mr Jeffrey Onganga from Gabon and he is the head of the Media and Public Relations. Hon Members, you are welcome. We wish you well and we pray that you enjoy Ghana. We believe you are already enjoying and you will enjoy more.

You have visited your Colleagues and we are at the Consideration Stage of a Bill. You are welcome once again.

[Members of the Pan-African Parliament and the Committee on Trade, Customs and Immigration were acknowledged.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, let us turn to clause 25. Yes, Chairman?

Clause 25 —Eligibility Criteria for Award of Scholarship.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, amendment proposed. Add the following new subclause:

“Despite subclause (1), the authority may, for the purpose of improving international cooperation, grant a scholarship to a person who is a non-Ghanaian.”

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, there is a proposed amendment to clause 25. Yes. Let me listen to the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment, Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo.

Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, this is a very good clause. It touches on Ghana's position from the very beginning when we granted scholarships to individuals in other countries, which enhanced our capacity as leaders in Africa. So, it is recapturing that flavour. But I am asking whether improving international relations could be the only reason we would be granting scholarship to a person from another country. It could also have some connotation in academic excellence, and some other reasons such as specialised areas of endeavour in academic work.

So, I am wondering whether we could not do a little amendment to reflect—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, let us hear you. What proposal do you make? Is there any rendition you are coming up with?

Dr Pelpuo: I was going to suggest that we say international cooperation as—And also as a result of academic excellence.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Minister, I will give you the opportunity. Sit down and craft the rendition you want us to have. So, Hon Leader?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, to seek clarification on clause 25,

“A person qualifies to apply for scholarship under this Act if the person is

(a) a Ghanaian; and

(b) brilliant but needy.”

Mr Speaker, the brilliant and needy part—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It is not “brilliant and needy”; it is “brilliant but needy”.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: All right, “brilliant but needy”. So, who determines who is needy? Mr Speaker, that is discrimination. So, if the Chairman can throw more lights on this. Who will determine a person who is needy? And with the discrimination laws that we have, if we want to be specific to say that the person must be brilliant but needy, we should look at it and let it come out very well or else it might offend other laws.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Dafeamekpor?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Mr Speaker, I believe that the phrase “brilliant but needy” has assumed the status of a term of art now and we are enacting it into our legislation.

Mr Speaker, the number one determinant of how brilliant a person is, is their transcript or terminal report; it is

the basic reference point. So, that is the basic reference point. Then, two, the circumstance.

5:14 p.m.

The circumstance could be that a person is from Hamile, and is making first class in engineering at Tarkwa. Now—Yes, there are, but I am saying that a person is from Hamile—We are using a circumstance. Or Mr Speaker, a person is from Agordeke in Afram Plains North, and is making first class. Apart from determining that they are brilliant, we are using further circumstances to establish that. So, that becomes a matter of discretion for the Board to exercise.

We do this in legislation all the time, provided that it is not abused, so that in determining who is brilliant but needy, the people are not concentrated in the elitist neighbourhoods. That is the essence of what we are doing, so that the opportunities are fairly distributed.

Mr Speaker, further to the amendment that is being proposed, international cooperation is so important because as we speak, the United Kingdom, the United States of America, the Kingdom of Morocco, the Federal Republics of Nigeria and India, and Australia, all award Ghanaian students, scholarships, using funds or revenues generated by the citizens of those countries.

So, it is to further our stance in the comity of nations that we can also legislate to reciprocate these gestures. Look at Cuba; Cuba takes a lot of our

young people every year. So, Mr Speaker, I believe that my Senior, Hon Rashid Pelpuo, will look at it, and if he is not minded to further his amendment, then we can carry the proposed amendment and make progress.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Nana Ayeh: Mr Speaker, I humbly seek your guidance. We have the proposed amendments with us, and we have the Bill as well. Clause 25 of the Bill states the categories for which the scholarship will be given. Now, the proposed amendment is suggesting other support or conditions.

Mr Speaker, if any Member here thinks that there are problems with what the proposal is making, the person should make the proposal, so that you put a question on it, because the suggestions have been made here. The item numbered (vii) reads,

“Despite subsection (1), the Authority may, for the purpose of improving international cooperation, grant a scholarship to a person who is a non-Ghanaian.”

Mr Speaker, it is not the point for you to justify whether it is good to be there or not. It is for you, Mr Speaker, to put the question on whether the House agrees for it to be part of the Bill.

Mr Speaker, again, when you go to the same clause, the item numbered (viii), it says,

“A scholarship awarded by the Authority shall be based on

- (a) the merit of the applicant;
- (b) the developmental need of the country; or
- (c) the need to improve international cooperation”

Mr Speaker, give us guidance.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you see, when you look at clause 25, it says that a person qualifies to apply for a scholarship under this Act if the person is a Ghanaian. So that is the basic qualification. But the amendment is that there may be an instance where the person may not be a Ghanaian, and under the circumstances, we may have to consider their application. Is that not the argument? That is why they are giving reasons for international cooperation. So I think the amendment is apt.

Nana Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker. That is all I am seeking to get.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Now, the same clause 25.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, the item numbered (viii), amendment proposed. Add the following new subclause:

“A scholarship awarded by the Authority shall be based on

- (a) the merit of the applicant;
- (b) the developmental need of the country; or
- (c) the need to improve international cooperation”

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, it is in furtherance of the other one. Hon Members, I do not see any problem with this.

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I think we need to be clear with what we are doing as far as clause 25 is concerned. If we look at the proposed amendment, it has two criteria: (a) a Ghanaian, and (b) a brilliant but needy. When we go to the amendment, we are talking about two different things that are also confusing.

Mr Speaker, if we are proposing despite subsection (a)1, then that becomes subsection 2. So now, we have to deal with subsection 1. If subsection 1 is (a) Ghanaian, (b) brilliant but needy. Then (c) will include the developmental needs of the country.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, Hon Member, you are missing the point. The first one is concluded; the person should be a Ghanaian, and the person should be brilliant but needy. Then they came up with an amendment that there could be a situation where a person may not be Ghanaian.

Dr Asamoah: Yes, but Mr Speaker, if we do not clarify that, it is going to be a problem because those two things should not be alone. In that case, I was

going to propose that the eligibility should also include meeting the eligibility criteria as determined by the Board. Because if we stick to only the two, which are a Ghanaian and brilliant but needy, it is not a standard that is used across the world as far as scholarships are concerned.

If you look at the stress-free tuition support, it is also a scholarship. And if we say only a brilliant but needy student, then we are taking some out. So, Mr Speaker, let us clearly look at—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, what do you suggest?

Dr Asamoah: I am suggesting that a person qualifies to apply for a scholarship under this Act if the person is “(a) a Ghanaian and (b) brilliant but needy, and to include (c) meet specific eligibility criteria as determined by the Board”. We should add that.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Fred, I must confess, I do not side with you, but I will put the question so that we move on.

Question put and amendment negated.

Hon Members, let me be frank with you. Today, I am not in the position to—
So, let us move on.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: No, it is important. Mr Speaker, you know I only come in when I have a good reason. I do not do this for the fun of it.

Mr Speaker, I am commenting on the amendment proposed, which has to do with the eligibility criteria. Here, it says, “a scholarship awarded by the Authority shall be based on the merit of the applicant”, which is fine, but the developmental needs of the country, that is where I have a problem.

5:24 p.m.

When we are discussing the eligibility criteria of the person. This is because if you take the heading, it says eligibility criteria for the award of scholarship, and we are dealing with the person. A person qualifies to apply, but when we are talking about the developmental needs, I think that is problematic as an eligibility criterion. Maybe you need to explain that to me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, hold on.

Yes, Hon Member.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Before you clarify, just to add to what he is saying, Hon Minister, if you look at what the amendment is saying, the developmental needs, you will see that if you move forward to clause 27, it talks about the consideration of application. I am making a proposal here that this amendment may better suit the consideration of application, where we are going to look at the developmental needs of—This is because in that area you talked about the priorities of the donor. In commenting, I think that amendment will suit clause 27 than at eligibility.

Now on eligibility, I just want a clarification, whether the consideration is put together, whether it has to be a Ghanaian and ‘brilliant but needy’, or they are separate. I am of the view that once the person has qualified to enter into any of our institutions, has admission, and continues to be there—There are a lot of people in my constituency who may not be able to pay their fees. But when we say ‘brilliant but needy’, then we are trying to segregate. I want that clarification from the Minister in affirming this. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Essikadu-Ketan?

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am trying to use this to explain the Hon Member of Effia’s question about the developmental needs of the country. Mr Speaker, I think that the clause 25 (b) is saying that these people will be chosen based on the developmental needs. For instance, if at that particular time the country needs biomedical engineering, it is a developmental need of the country. Once the biomedical engineering issue becomes a developmental problem, then the scholarship can go towards training more biomedical engineers to come and plug in the whole of the country, because now we need more biomedical engineers to take care of our medical equipment in the hospitals. That is why it is important that we put in the developmental needs. The National Development Planning Commission (NDPC) will have developmental needs that come up as we go along. It is important that at some

point the developmental needs of the country becomes important in how we award scholarships. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: For instance, for a couple of years, the Republic of Cuba has been assisting Ghanaian medical doctors because they realised that Ghana needed that angle of profession. Therefore, they offered scholarship for Ghanaians to come and study Medicine, so that we can come back and help our country. That becomes the developmental need of Ghana. If Cuba was then supporting Ghana by way of scholarship, they would look at the developmental needs of Ghana, and that was it. I think that is the same way this particular Bill is trying to capture it.

Yes, Mr Shaibu, you may put up the rendition again so that I can put the Question and move on.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, before the Hon Member for Daboya/Mankarigu comes in, I have listened to the debate and I appreciate the intervention of our Colleague who thinks that this belongs to clause 27, so we can have clause 27 (1) and (2).

But, Mr Speaker, eligibility criteria for the award of scholarship—When the phrase “developmental need” was used, Ghana ought to have had a manpower development plan developed by the NDPC that would give a focus of our human resource requirement into the future. However, Mr Speaker, specific as you are giving your own example, for instance, take Artificial Intelligence, it is now the norm. Everybody is talking

about Artificial Intelligence. Which university in Ghana are you going to learn Artificial Intelligence? But to prepare Ghana for a world to be driven by Artificial Intelligence, you can dedicate scholarship to Ghanaians to go and study Artificial Intelligence. However, as was observed by the Hon Majority Chief Whip, Mr Speaker, reciprocal—Why we want to add it to eligibility is that—Indeed, maybe tomorrow when I am coming, I will carry it. I have a letter sitting in my office from the Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs about ECOWAS citizens who want to be able to study in and who have been promised some scholarship, they can only come under this international cooperation and reciprocal leg.

Mr Speaker, I will add that you put the Question and then we progress. Thank you.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I believe that the clause is very wide-open. We need to be clear about who is proposing the developmental need. I believe that we might have to do an amendment as specific that NDPC—If we do not do that, what will be happening is that everybody will be waiting for somebody and then we will be creating our own developmental needs and not serving anybody. We should be specific so that if each year we get the list; we can use that as a basis to—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Mr Darko-Mensah I think the Bill is explicit that a person who qualifies should in the first place be a Ghanaian, and secondly,

the person should be brilliant but needy. These are the main requirements. Because it is insisted that the person should be a Ghanaian—They are coming with a proposed amendment that there could be an instance whereby somebody may not be a Ghanaian but we may have to probably extend our support to that person. That is where this requirement is also coming in, that the person should merit it. Even though the person is not a Ghanaian, we have to consider his application on merit. Then, sub clause (b), the developmental need of the country. Like we are Ghanaians, and the person applying is a Togolese, but we have to consider the need of Togo as a country.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I think the understanding is that we can give scholarship to an ECOWAS person, but that person, in the long run, should still fit within the developmental needs of Ghana because we are saying that when people go outside, they should come back and serve, having gotten the scholarship from Ghana. I think that is primary.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No. Now we are talking about a non-Ghanaian, and the developmental need that we will consider will be the need of that country. Just as I was using the medical students who went to Cuba as an instance. That is also one angle. Of course, the third one is to improve international cooperation because we probably want to—So that is the angle, and I think it is a good thing.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I see the mischief. Hon Minister, there is a little mischief. In the earlier amendment

we carried under clause 25, we should indicate in the second amendment we seek to carry that ‘a scholarship awarded by the Authority under...’ This is because the Clerks-at-Table will indicate whether that will be clause 25—*[Interruption]*—That amendment was carried under clause 25 after ‘brilliant but needy’. That will be clause 25 (1). Then we will introduce clause 25 (2) that despite subsection 1. Yes, a preambular clause. The introduction of the phrase, “the developmental need of the country”, the phrase “of the country” is what is creating the problem.

5:34 p.m.

Because the introduction of the phrase “the developmental need of the country”, “of the country” is what is creating the problem, whether the person of the country means that Ghana, the country, granted the scholarship or the country of origin of the beneficiary.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The country of the origin of the beneficiary.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Exactly. So, it should be “scholarship awarded by the authority under subsection 2”, so, it cures it because it is the developmental needs of Ghana for which we are awarding the scholarship.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: I was actually going to request that the Hon Minister for Education gives the policy guidance. What is the intent behind that? Is it the developmental needs of Ghana or the developmental needs of the country which that person is coming from? That policy guidance is what will solve this problem.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, Ghana.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, did you say Ghana? Then I do not seem to —Hon Minister, my understanding is that we have considered that the basic requirement is a Ghanaian. Now we are stating further that there could be a situation whereby a non-Ghanaian would need to be supported and that is where all these criteria are coming from. The person should be brilliant —

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, let me withdraw my retorted answer of “Ghana” and explain that, I agree with you on the thinking of the international cooperation and others. Indeed, I even turned to Hon Member for Daboya/Mankarigu and the Chairman to say that we may have to add a subclause (c) that under exceptional circumstances a non-Ghanaian could benefit from a scholarship. Exceptional circumstances, for instance, somebody wants to come and learn *Adowa* of the Asante culture. He may not be a Ghanaian but he wants to come and learn something about Ghana or the folklores of Ghana. We may want to encourage the person. —*[Interruption]* —No, I am just giving an example. We may want to encourage such people to know more about our country and we can dedicate scholarships to support that. But I am guided by your brilliance on the development needs, so Hon Nkrumah should ignore my answer and let us make progress.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Mahama? No, let me give the opportunity to the new Member in the House.

Prof Seidu Mahama Alidu: Mr Speaker, thank you so much, for the opportunity. I just want to speak to the fact that whether the criteria of considering cooperation inure to the benefit of Ghana or another country, I think it can be both. In most circumstances, what we have to look at is the developmental challenge of the partner country we are dealing with, and we can give scholarship to students in that particular country to be able to help settle their developmental needs. But in other cases, it could also be informed by our national interests. So, for example, if we want to achieve a particular interest in another country, we can sponsor students in that particular country and in that specific topic, to be able to get our national interests met.

For example, the United States of America, in trying to project the whole concept of liberal democracy, sponsors students in developing countries to come and learn political science and democracy. When they go back to their country, they would be able to preach and teach the ethics and values of democracy to their people. That opens up the system for debate and for America to project their national interests. So, what we can do is to look at Ghana's national interest in neighbouring countries and specific courses that can help us to achieve that particular interest in those countries, then we give scholarships to students from those countries to come

and pursue that specific course. So that when they go, they can expand their interests and the needs of the Ghanaian population there. So, it can be both in that regard.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, let me put the Question.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, this one, a regulation will finetune some of these matters.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Shaibu Mahama, give us the rendition, then we will move on.

Mr S. Mahama: Mr Speaker, the reason I did not want that the second amendment to clause 25 to stay but should rather be moved to clause 27 is, if we look at clause 25, the gravamen of clause 25 is eligibility. So, the three sub-clauses that we have proposed sit there, "Eligibility criteria for award of scholarship". One, "Ghanaian"; two, "brilliant but needy". Three, contemplates a situation where one may not be a Ghanaian, but because of international cooperation – indeed, we were the first to even name our Ministry, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration. Three contemplates that another criterion would be a non-Ghanaian, so these three should sit under clause 25.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It should sit under clause 25. So, it means we should rather establish another sub-clause.

Mr S. Mahama: So, the viii, which now talks about the merits, should not sit under eligibility criteria. The headnote is clear on that, except if we want to amend the headnote and add other things. But it is clearly an eligibility criterion. However, if we come to clause 27, it talks about “Consideration of application”. If we now want to go to the merits of the applicants and the application that has been submitted, then we can drop that under clause 27, so we pull that off from this and then we leave it that way.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. That is what the Hon Member for Okere suggested. So, if that is the way we want to —

Mr S. Mahama: I agree with my learned friend. My friend in smock.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, it means we should maintain clause 25 then when we go to clause 27 for “Consideration of Application”, then we can look at that. Is that the pleasure of the House?

Some Hon Members: Yes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We will hold on to clause 25 and we will abandon this amendment —

Some Hon Members: No.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Chairman, should I put the Question on the — Very well.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me put the Question to the entire clause 25.— No, we will come to the Second Consideration Stage then we will look at —

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I thought it was a mistake in your —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: What is it?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Question you put to the House was to the effect of those in support of the second amendment in clause 25.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, we have already done the first amendment.

Dr Mahama: The sense I had from the Chairman was to the effect that the second amendment in clause 25 would be deferred to clause 27. The first amendment is what you are putting the Question to and it lies within clause 25. So, if you are putting the Question on the first amendment, you are right. But on the second amendment, it was deferred to clause 25 and that is what I want to clarify.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Dr Kabiru, I thought the first amendment we considered in clause 25 was the one that dealt with — Yes. So, I think that one has been done.

Dr Mahama: Yes, but you did not put the Question.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I put the Question.

5:44 p.m.

When I said the second one, that meant I was referring to this.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, since we are at the Consideration Stage, I will seek your leave —And Colleagues, the Hon Member for Daboya/Mankarigu is a modern drafter; I still belong to the old school of drafting.

Mr Speaker, if we want to move clause 25 to clause 27 as was earlier suggested by our Colleague, Mr Shaibu Mahama, it will read:

“Eligibility criteria for award of scholarship”

25. A person qualifies to apply for a scholarship under this Act if the person is

(a) a Ghanaian; and

(b) brilliant but needy.”

On the basis of the arguments, we have all advanced, so we may have to provide for a subsection (c), “a non-Ghanaian under exceptional circumstances determined by the Board.” Then Mr Speaker can put the Question overall on the three items. Mr Speaker, you can direct the drafters to take note of that. “A non-Ghanian can benefit from scholarship but under exceptional circumstances determined by the Board.” I so submit.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I think we will help you because clause 25 says “Ghanaian”, which we do not have a problem with. It also says “brilliant and needy”, which we do not have a problem with. But the first amendment that was passed by this House was to the effect that despite subclause 1, “the Authority may, for the purposes of improving international cooperation, grant scholarship to a person who is a non-Ghanaian”. This one still stays under clause 25; it does not move to clause 27 because it provides the caveat that we can award scholarship to a foreigner or a non-Ghanian based on international cooperation or whatever reason it is. And I agree —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Then we would go to clause 27 and give the parameters—

Dr Mahama: No, clause 27 is the second amendment which talks about the merits of the application, development needs of the country, and the need to improve international cooperation. That will go to clause 25, but the current rendition should be as it is.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think I am inclined to go with Dr Mahama.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am just thinking, does it not restrain us to only international cooperation? If we come in and talk about other circumstances rather than just international cooperation—We do not have to have an international cooperation with a country before we consider giving some foreigners

scholarship. It does not necessarily have to be only based on international cooperation; it could be exceptional circumstances. For instance, somebody came to Ghana, we found the person galivanting, but we saw that the person has some great brilliance and we want to adopt and support the person.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The person can even be here under a refugee status.

Mr Shaib: Yes, and that is not international cooperation. So, I think that the Minister's rendition should still hold.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, with your leave, we could have subclause (c) and (d). Subclause (c) would be non-Ghanian under exceptional circumstances, then subclause (d) would be the international cooperation.

Thank you.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the problem with the “exceptional circumstances” is that — *[Interruption]* — With the greatest respect to the Minister for Education, that his girlfriend is in Mozambique. *[Laughter]* He would bring his girlfriend from Mozambique and say under exceptional circumstances. Can I make my point? Let me use Mr Mahama as an example. We do not want a situation where the Chairman of the Committee on Education would say that his friend is in Mozambique.

Mr Speaker, all across the countries, if there is a need to promote our

language, it has to come through the government; government to government. We do not want an individual coming to the country to apply to say that we are promoting this, so let us give the person a scholarship. Let us bring it through the cooperation; let us do it government to government, and let us do it bilateral. But we should not open it for individuals to apply because there is a programme and we are promoting a certain end.

So, Mr Speaker, let us leave it at “international cooperation”.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, we will take it as the Chairman presented it.

Hon Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamakor: Mr Speaker, we have spent about 30 minutes on this matter and I believe the amendments that we have carried are such that if we feel strongly about introducing a few other matters, we would have the opportunity to do so tomorrow. Or a Regulation would be brought which will fine-tune some of these matters we are raising. So, I suggest that you put the Question and let us make progress. When we get to 32, then we can —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. While we move on, we can even take a Second Consideration when the need be.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 25 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 26 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 27 — Consideration of Application.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, clause 27, amendment proposed, *delete and insert* the following:

“27. In assessing an application for scholarship under section 26, consideration shall be given to

- a. the academic excellence of the applicant;
- b. the financial need of the applicant;
- c. the leadership and extra-curricular involvement by the applicant;
- (d) the special talent and skill of the applicant;
- (e) the field of study and career goal of the applicant;
- (f) a person with disability;
- (g) letter of recommendation for the applicant; and
- (h) the priorities of the donor institution.”.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, further amendment by the insertion of subclause (i), “Special circumstance of the applicant”. This proposed amendment to include subclause (i) is to the effect that we are building a country where we want inclusive scholarship programme to include persons with disability. The Scholarship Fund could target people who are disabled, or disabled applicants could be given consideration by virtue of the fact that they are disabled. That promotes inclusion. And I think that if we include that, our views would be more disability friendly than it currently stands.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is it the case that the Bill as it stands now is discriminating against people with disability? Is that the case?

5:54 p.m.

Dr Mahama: Because sub clause (f) addresses the point, but I was just thinking that beyond that, could there be other special circumstances.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I was thinking you were going to talk about the external factors that people — All right, then let me hear you. Leader, I will come to you.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Leader, let me have this one in my name. Thank you, Mr Speaker. As discussed earlier, I propose a further amendment that the earlier proposed amendment for clause 25 which says “the merits of the application, the developmental need of the country, and the need to improve

international cooperation” be brought to clause 27. I so propose. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So probably we have to couch the rendition well. That in case the Secretariat is considering international applications, they should look at it from this angle. Is that right?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the initial proposal was to make the present amendment as advertised and carried, 27 (1) (a) to (h). Then the amendment earlier carried under 25 would have been taken from there structurally and brought under this to make it 27(2) because of the head notes. So, if the House agrees, then the drafters can do that easily.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, fantastic.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, I want some guidance from the Hon Minister on this particular one, which is (e): “field of study and career goal of the applicant”. So, I am trying to find out from the Minister whether some brilliant but needy students would not be accepted by the Scholarship Secretariat because of their field of study and career goal? It looks a bit discriminatory.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: If it is not the focus of the Secretariat that time, like somebody said, we are looking for engineers so we want to support more engineers so that Ghana can prosper the way we want it. So, if an applicant is an art student, even though they may be brilliant, the Secretariat can say that at the moment, the focus of the scholarship

is to look for engineers or to look for science students. So, they can use that as a criterion to turn down their application. That is my understanding anyway.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, that is why I want to get that from the Hon Minister since you are a Speaker. Because it looks a bit discriminatory. This is because we are talking about a scholarship for Ghanaians and we are talking about brilliant but needy. But the (e) looks a bit discriminatory. It means that there will be a time that somebody will apply, but because the field of study and the career goal of that individual do not align with the Scholarship Secretariat, that person will be denied.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes. It is done everywhere.

Mr Nyindam: I do not have a problem. I just want to get it, Mr Speaker.

Mr Darko Mensah: Mr Speaker, I believe that it is very important that we are clear on this matter. Because if we do not know where we are going as a country on a systematic basis, we will be giving scholarships for no apparent reason. We need to give scholarships for the goal that this country wants to achieve. So, if it is science, maybe for the next five years, we will decide to recruit for science. If it is for psychology, we can decide, and that is what we should be doing. So, I believe that it is very important that we keep this clause in there.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, very important.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, humbly, I think even in clause 27, line 2, I do not think it should even be consideration because the whole checklist is for consideration but it should be priority. Priority shall be given to (a) to (h)—[*Interruption*—All right, if it is evaluation, I am sure we can do it.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 27 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, the drafters should please take note. As Hon Dafeamekpor said, we are going to have a (2) that will take care of— in case of international application, then we will also capture the amendment that was brought by the Hon Member for Okere which means that we will be lifting the 25 to that section.

Alhaji Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, given that and knowing some other matters, I think that we can bring the curtains down at 30 so that we allow you to retire. But Mr Speaker, before you do that, may I seek your leave and indulgence once again on clause 26. “An application for scholarship under this Act shall be made to the Authority”. Even though, Mr Speaker, the question was put, “online” should be “electronic”. The language in information and communication technology is not online, but the application should be electronic. Mr Speaker, if you can tolerate me and re-put the question.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Minister, I will just ask the drafters to look at it. So, we will take clause 28.

Clause 28 — Award of scholarship.

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, amendment proposed: Line 1, after “shall”, delete “in consultation with”, and insert “subject to the approval of”.

So, the new rendition will be “the Director-General shall with prior approval of the Board award scholarships under this Act.” I so move, Mr Speaker.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 28 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clauses 29 and 30 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

6:04 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: On that note, we will bring consideration to a close.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leadership, any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it is just about 6:00 p.m. We have not done more than five hours, so we are in your hands.

Mr Speaker, before we move for adjournment, let me put this matter across to especially leadership of Committees that the 2:00 p.m. Sitting

was agreed on, hinged mainly on the fact that Committee works will be done mainly in the mornings. But we have discovered that a lot of Committee meetings have been slated for the afternoons, with some even at 2:00 p.m. when the House is supposed to be convening. So even though we are just back from recess, we appear depleted anytime we convene in the Chamber, and it is not helping. Today, the Rt Hon Speaker have had cause to speak to the issue. Yes, we agree that the Committees must work, but let us work within the time frames so that we help the Chamber to also carry out its Business.

So, we are pleading with the leadership of Committees to agree with their Clerks to schedule Committee business for the morning. So that when it is 1:45 p.m., we can all get to the Chamber and start Business at 2:00 p.m.

Mr Speaker, having said that, we are entirely in your hands and we know that the mood of the House is that we bring today's Business to a close. I believe my Counterpart, the distinguished Ahmed Shaib will not oppose this one, so that we can adjourn for the day.

I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I understand we started proceedings at 2:35 p.m.; we have not crossed the five-hour mark. So, move a Motion.

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Kwami Etse Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, in the absence of any further Business, I move that the House be adjourned for today till tomorrow at 2:00 p.m.

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, we are not opposed to the Motion save that today is a sad day for some of us.

Mr Speaker, we have been told of the very sad news of your mother's passing. I do not know where you had your strength to even sit for an hour or two. I think you are a very strong man. I would still be crying if it were to be my mother, and I am praying that she will not die now because if she dies, Baba is not ready to take care of me.

Mr Speaker, we pray that God gives you the strength, the wherewithal to brave the storm in this trying time. We pray for divine strength. I do not know how you are taking this, but my prayer is that—

Mr Speaker, I do not know if I am actually allowed to do this, but I just wish you well, and I pray that my Colleagues will join us in sympathising with you. We condole with you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it is a tragedy. We were hoping that we would have allowed you to go home, and when you returned, then—But once it has been announced, it has become official.

On behalf of the Leadership and the entire House, and of course, the Rt Hon Speaker, we extend our deepest condolences to you. You are journeying home, so when you go, whatever the arrangements are, Mr Speaker, keep the

House informed so that we can support you. We are with you emotionally and spiritually; be strong. Death, be not proud.

Mr Speaker, our deepest condolences to you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. The Motion for

adjournment has been moved and seconded.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 6:10 p.m. till Thursday, 30th October, 2025, at 2:00 p.m.

